

AGE OF MYTHOS

East — Chapter 1 — Rise of Legends

East · Purva · English Edition

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Kalinga Chakra — The War Against Grief Itself

In 261 BCE, Emperor Ashoka invaded Kalinga. One hundred thousand died. Ashoka, seeing the carnage, wept — and from his tears came Buddhism's spread across Asia, the edicts of non-violence carved in stone, and the greatest moral transformation in any ruler's history.

But what about the dead?

Kalinga-Yama rose from the battlefield two thousand years after the blood had seeped into the soil. He was not a ghost — ghosts are memories. He was something worse: he was the feeling of 100,000 deaths, concentrated into a single walking wound. He looked like a warrior but he was made of grief, and grief does not die. It just waits.

Jagannathi was the first to face him, and the first to understand the horror of his power. The Grief Blade did not cut — it touched, and the person touched felt every sorrow they had ever suppressed crash over them like a tidal wave. Three of her best warriors dropped their weapons and wept. Two never recovered.

But Jagannathi is a builder, not a fighter, and builders see problems differently. She understood that Kalinga-Yama was not an enemy to be defeated but a wound to be healed. The question was not "how do we kill grief?" but "how do we process grief so great that it took physical form?"

She built the Wheel of Remembrance — a massive stone wheel modeled on the Konark Sun Temple's chariot wheels, erected on the exact spot where the Battle of Kalinga was fought. Every family in Odisha carved a name onto the wheel — not just the ancient dead, but their own dead. Parents who lost children to floods. Children who lost parents to illness. The wheel became a repository of acknowledged grief, and acknowledged grief is grief that begins to heal.

Kalinga-Yama stood before the wheel and, for the first time, something other than grief crossed his face. Recognition. These people were not fighting him — they were seeing him. All he had ever wanted was for someone to understand the weight he carried.

He has not attacked since. But he has not disappeared either. He sits at the base of the wheel, listening to the names being carved, and the Indian Rollers circle above him — tumbling through the sky, falling and rising, as if showing him that descent is not defeat.

Jagannathi watches him carefully. Her twin daughters — born without the expected sambar deer tattoo — may be the key to either sealing Kalinga-Yama's power forever or releasing it. She has not decided which would be more merciful.

The wheel turns. It always turns.

Sagara Ratna — The Unlocking

A double-outrigger canoe between Little Andaman and Car Nicobar. October monsoon. Black water under black sky. A woman labours in the bottom of the boat, gripping the mast for the pain. Her husband — an Onge tribesman — holds her shoulders. The mid-wife is the woman's own mother, the one she carved canoes with. Her name is Aki.

The woman is a Bloodline-E descendant of the Sagaravamsha — shipwrecked here at eleven, kept by the tribe that found her, married into them at twenty-three. She is forty now and giving birth in a storm she helped sail through.

She names the child as he comes: Onge-Nakshatra. The Onge people, and a star.

The lightning shows them his face. Aki looks at the lightning. She looks at the child. She looks up at the constellation Mrigashira, just visible between cloud-breaks.

"He sees in two directions," she says. "He will need both."

Twenty-six years later, Onge-Nakshatra has the chest-paint of Mrigashira reapplied each dawn. He has sailed every channel between every island in the Andaman and Nicobar archipelago. He speaks four tribal languages, two mainland ones, and reads Bloodline-E sea-charts that his mother taught him from memory because her own copies sank with the ship that brought her.

He has never sailed past Indira Point. The horizon south of that is Volume II, and the islands have not let him go yet.

The Andamans and Nicobars are not one kingdom. They are forty-seven inhabited islands and another five hundred uninhabited ones. They are six recognized tribes and one tribe (the North Sentinelese) that has refused contact for sixty thousand years. They are coconut-trade routes between cousins, drum-codes carried on monsoon wind, and the silent watching of a saltwater crocodile in every cove.

They are also a wound. Every empire that ever ruled the mainland sent the worst of its problems here. The British perfected the cruelty — they built the Cellular Jail in Port Blair in 1906, a seven-spoked radial prison designed so that no prisoner could see another prisoner ever. It held men until 1947. Some of those men were freedom fighters. Some

were thieves. Some had been arrested for crimes that were not crimes in their own villages. None of their pain went anywhere when the jail emptied.

Onge-Nakshatra has been to the jail. Every island child is taken there once. The walls are cold even in summer. There is a smell that does not match a museum.

A tour group at the Cellular Jail museum, October. Twenty-seven people, mostly mainland tourists, a guide with a clipboard. They are in the central watchtower at sunset, the time the guides do not usually allow because the lighting is bad. But this group is special — a foreign documentary team — and the museum has made an exception.

At sunset, the doors to the central tower close. All seven spoke-doors of all three remaining wings close at once. The guide tries the handle. It does not move. The tourists laugh, nervously. The guide laughs less.

The lights flicker. They flicker between modern electric bulb and 1906 oil lamp. The painted museum signs — bilingual, modern — show, for one breath, the original 1906 British placards. The smell that does not match a museum becomes the smell that matches a jail.

A man walks down the central spiral staircase. He wears colonial khaki. A brass meter swings at his belt. In his right hand is a wheel made of seven iron spokes that turns slowly, of its own accord. His face is too thin to be his own.

"Welcome to Kala Pani," he says. "You are not the first to ask if you may leave."

The doors do not open until dawn. By then, three tourists have suffered cardiac events. Two are dead. The foreign documentary team has uploaded twenty seconds of footage before their cameras failed; that footage is what tells the islands that something has come back.

He calls a council. The tribal elders refuse to come to Port Blair — too far, too mainland, too compromised. He travels to each island separately by his outrigger. Each elder says yes to a meeting, then suggests it should be on their own island, on their terms, with their own ceremonies.

The Jarawa want a meeting on South Andaman near their reserve boundary. The Great Andamanese want it at Strait Island. The Nicobari want it at Car Nicobar. The Shompen want it at Great Nicobar interior. The Onge — his own people — say Onge-Nakshatra should host, but only on Little Andaman, and not with non-Onge present.

Each tribe is correct on their own terms. The terms do not overlap.

Aki, his grandmother, watches him plan four separate council meetings on four separate islands across two months and says nothing. She does carve, sometimes, while he speaks. Once she carves a single broken paddle and sets it on the sand beside his foot. He does not understand the message.

Three weeks after the awakening. The jail-museum has been closed by the government. The military have set a cordon. Communications around Port Blair are unreliable in a way no one can explain. Ships in the harbour cannot leave at night. The harbour-master has gone missing. His office is locked from the inside.

Onge-Nakshatra cannot wait for the tribal councils to align. He goes alone.

He paddles into Port Blair harbour past midnight. The saltwater crocodile of his bond — a six-meter male who lives in the South Bay mangroves — follows him at depth. The Nicobar Pigeon flies over the harbour once and then turns back. The bird will not land.

He enters the jail through a sea-passage in the cliff below the central tower — a tunnel only the crocodile-bond reveals, used by the British to dump bodies into the bay without records. The tunnel is wet. The salt has eaten the iron bars over a century.

Kalapani-Asura is waiting in the central tower. The seven spoke-corridors radiate from his feet. The Sapta-Shala turns in his right hand.

"You came as a tribesman," the asura says. "You came as an outrigger sailor. You came as one man speaking for many. Do you know what this jail was built for?"

"To break the men who could organize the islands."

"To break the men who tried to speak for many. The jail learned the lesson before the mainland did. One man speaking for many is the form that always loses. So." A gesture. The nearest spoke-corridor seals itself. "Stay. Be one man speaking for one. The cell is honest. The cell will hold you for as long as your pride does."

Onge-Nakshatra swings the Sagara-Bandhu. The anchor strikes the iron of the cell door. The salt-rope hisses. The lock gives. He runs into the next corridor. That corridor seals. He runs the next. Sealed. He runs all seven. The Sapta-Shala turns. Every corridor he runs into seals behind him as he passes.

He fights for an hour. He hits walls and they hold. He hits doors and they hold. He hits the asura and the asura is not entirely there — the iron wheel deflects him, the body wears Whitley but the pain is older. He is being herded toward the central cell.

He reaches the sea-passage by luck — the crocodile of his bond is at the water-line below, exhaling. Onge-Nakshatra hears the exhale. He drops through a grate. He is in the sea before he knows he chose to fall.

The Sapta-Shala turns behind him. The asura does not follow into salt water. The asura will not enter open sea.

He returns to Little Andaman before dawn. His arm is broken at the wrist. His chest-paint is scrubbed off by the swim. He has not slept in thirty-one hours.

A Nicobar Pigeon lands on the sand beside the canoe. He does not see it for the first minute, but it does not fly off. When he looks up, it tilts its head.

Aki is at the cave mouth. She has carved a new piece — a paddle that is whole this time. She hands it to him without comment.

He sits on the sand. He looks at the paddle. He looks at the canoe. He looks at the Pigeon.

He says, "I went alone."

She does not nod or speak. She taps the carving once with her thumb.

He understands.

"You came back. The horizon asked. I gave it a name and a council that could not meet. I did not give it bows turned toward it."

Tap tap. Two taps. No.

He looks at her. She has never said no to him in three years.

She taps the paddle. Then the canoe. Then her own chest. Then the open sea.

He says, slowly: "The bow turned toward the horizon. Not the horizon as enemy. The horizon as question. I have been answering the wrong question."

She nods. Once. The Pigeon takes off.

The question was never how to organize the tribes against the mainland-ghost. The question was how to organize the islands so the ghost loses its ground. Isolation is not

strength. It is the disease the asura offers as cure.

He does not call another council. He calls a festival.

Word goes out through Nicobari-Khol's trade routes — the coconut and coir circuits that touch every inhabited island. The Festival of the First Canoe. An invitation, not a summons. Each tribe is asked to send three canoes — no more, no fewer — to Havelock on the first full moon of December. They are to bring food, drum, song, and one elder. They are not to bring weapons. They are also not to leave their weapons at home — they are to leave them at a single agreed sea-cave on the way, where they will be returned at the festival's end.

It is a strange request. Most tribes laugh. Several refuse outright.

Nicobari-Khol delivers the invitations in person. He takes weeks. He speaks six languages. He drinks bad tea with elders who do not trust each other. He says: Onge-Nakshatra is calling the festival because the Jail awoke. He says: the Jail is what happens when no island talks to its neighbour for a hundred years. He says: come not for him, come for the canoe.

By December full moon, forty-seven canoes have come to Havelock. From every tribe. From the Onge, Jarawa, Great Andamanese, Nicobari, Shompen — and from mainland-Bengali fishermen who were invited as guests because the Bay of Bengal is also part of the kingdom's edge. The Sentinelese do not come; the Sentinelese never come.

But: at the highest point of the eastern cliff of Havelock, a silhouette appears at dawn on day one. A man with a hollowed log on his hip. He drums a rhythm. The Onge elders look up and weep. The Sentinelese have sent a Brother. They have not sent one in eighty-one years. The drum is a permission.

For three days, the islands do what they have not done in a century. Tribes share food across mats. Translators sit cross-legged between elders. The Nicobari serve coconut-crab roast to Onge elders who have never eaten with non-Onge before. A Jarawa woman teaches a Bengali fisherman the bow-grip that lets you shoot fish underwater. A Shompen man explains his people's nine words for different sea-floor textures.

A mainland-Bengali fisherman, on the second night, stands up and asks to speak. He is granted the speaking shell. He says, in slow Bengali that Nicobari-Khol translates: "We — the mainland — apologized too late. We are still apologizing too late. I do not have the

authority to apologize for India. I have the authority to apologize for my grandfather who fished these waters and threw your nets into the sea so we could keep the fish. I apologize."

A Jarawa elder takes the shell. He says — Nicobari-Khol translates — "We accept that you do not have authority. We accept the apology you have. The apology is a paddle. We can hold a paddle."

The Sentinel-Brother drums.

He cannot let the festival hold. On the third night of the festival, he activates the Mauna-Tantra — the colonial-era brass meter that jams all radio signals within twenty kilometers and overlays the silence with recorded prisoner-screams from the jail's worst nights.

Some canoes returning to outer islands lose their bearing. One Shompen canoe with three men aboard does not arrive home. They are found two weeks later — alive, badly dehydrated, on an uninhabited islet, having survived by chewing pandanus root. Two more canoes are damaged on reefs that should have been radioed. The cost is real.

The festival debates whether to end early. Some elders argue: the asura cannot be defeated by canoes. We have made our peace. Now we go home.

Onge-Nakshatra speaks. He says: if we go home, every island is alone again, and the asura wins by absence. We do not go home. We sail to the Cellular Jail. Together. With all forty-seven canoes. The asura's wheel locks one space at a time. It cannot lock forty-seven canoes' worth of harbour at once.

The Sentinel-Brother drums a rhythm. Aki, who has not left Little Andaman in nine years, is helped into a canoe by her great-niece. She comes too.

Dawn on the fourth day. Forty-seven canoes enter Port Blair harbour in a single broad arc. The saltwater crocodile of Onge-Nakshatra's bond leads them at the surface. The Nicobar Pigeon flies above the centre canoe. Above the eastern cliff of the harbour, the Sentinel-Brother drums a pattern that no living person can identify but every tribal elder recognises by feel.

Kalapani-Asura is in the central tower of the Cellular Jail. He raises the Sapta-Shala. He locks the harbour gate — the entire entrance. Every canoe will be trapped inside the harbour. He locks the breakwater. He locks the lighthouse beam. He turns the Mauna-Tantra to maximum.

The canoes drift. The radios die. The screams of prisoners begin to overlay the air.

Onge-Nakshatra is in the lead canoe with Hutto-Mara, Nicobari-Khol, and Aki. He says to Aki: "What now?"

She points at the Cellular Jail with her chisel.

He understands. The asura is locking the harbour. The harbour can be locked. The harbour is one space. The jail is also one space. The asura cannot lock the jail and the harbour at the same time — his wheel has seven spokes, but his attention is one.

Onge-Nakshatra slips into the water. The crocodile takes him on its back below the surface. They swim the sea-passage he used before. The crocodile dives under the cliff. Onge-Nakshatra holds his breath for ninety seconds — the bond-discipline of his line. He surfaces inside the tunnel under the central tower. He climbs.

He emerges in the central tower behind Kalapani-Asura. The asura does not turn. He is concentrating on the harbour-lock.

Onge-Nakshatra raises the Sagara-Bandhu. He says, conversationally:

"You said the jail learned the lesson before the mainland. One man speaking for many always loses. That is true. So I am not speaking for many. They speak for themselves."

He swings the anchor in a horizontal arc — the water-pulling arc, the typhoon-circle. The salt-rope catches the Sapta-Shala. The salt eats the seven-spoke wheel's central axle. The wheel falls apart in the asura's hand.

Every cell door in every wing opens at once.

Kalapani-Asura turns. His face — Whitley's face — opens in shock. "You released them."

"I released what you held. They were not yours to keep."

The ghosts walk out of the cells. Not all at once — they are slow. They are men in 1906 clothes, men in 1942 clothes, men whose bodies have not been seen in a century. They walk down the seven spoke-corridors. They walk out of the central tower. They walk through the breakwater, which the asura has stopped locking because he is too distracted. They walk into the harbour. They walk into the sea.

Varuna receives them. The saltwater crocodile, watching from the surface, parts the water for each one. Each ghost goes under and does not come up.

The pain that held the body of Robert Whitley begins to drain. It drains slowly. There is a lot of pain. But each ghost that walks out is a measure of pain released. By the time the last ghost — a Burmese man named Maung Aye, sentenced in 1924 for organizing a school — walks past Kalapani-Asura, the asura is shrinking. Whitley's khaki hangs loose on him. The brass meter falls from his belt and shatters.

He looks at Onge-Nakshatra. He is, now, just Robert Whitley — the actual ghost of the actual last warden, very small, very old.

"I did not want this assignment," Whitley says, in 1948 English. "I was sent. I was twenty-four."

"I know."

"I did not know how to leave."

"None of us do. The horizon asks every morning. The answer is to point the bow."

Onge-Nakshatra says Whitley's name aloud — Robert Andrew Whitley, born Yorkshire 1923, posted Port Blair 1946, hanged March 1948, never named in any official Indian record. He says the name three times. Whitley weeps. He fades into the morning air the way the others faded into the sea.

The festival canoes have come into the harbour. Forty-seven canoes plus the rescue boats, plus the harbour-master who has been found unharmed in a locked supply room. The tribes are on the docks. Aki is helped onto the stone steps of the Cellular Jail by her great-niece.

A Nicobar Pigeon descends on the central tower's broken weathervane. It tilts its head. It stays.

Onge-Nakshatra's tattoo finishes its first stage — the crocodile rises from his lower back to his upper arm, the head turned toward the harbour, the tail wrapped around his shoulder. The chest-paint of Mrigashira flares for a moment in dawn light.

The Sentinel-Brother drums one final pattern — the closing rhythm of a long journey. He turns and disappears into the inland forest of North Sentinel. He will not be seen again for a generation.

Aki carves something while the elders speak. A small canoe. Six inches long. She hands it to her grandson. He sets it carefully on the harbour water. The little canoe finds a current.

It points its bow at the south horizon.

Past Indira Point. Past the lighthouse. Toward Yavana-Khanda.

The sea does ask a question every morning. The bow is the answer. The kingdom of Sagara-Ratna has, for the first time in its memory, more than one bow pointing in the same direction.

The sea remembers who came uninvited. It also remembers who came to free them.

Sundara Vana — The Swamp That Swallows

Nothing in the Sundarbans is what it seems. The ground is water. The water is mud. The trees breathe through their roots and the roots reach upward like drowning hands. In this place, the fishing cat is king — not because it is the strongest, but because it is the only predator patient enough to hunt in water that has no bottom.

Sundarvani learned patience the hard way. Her mother walked into the mangroves one morning when Sundarvani was seven, carrying nothing but a bowl of rice. She said she was going to feed the forest. She never came back. The villagers said the tigers took her. The tantrics said the forest took her. Sundarvani knows the truth is worse: her mother chose the forest over her family, drawn by the same pull that tugs at Sundarvani's own heart every time the tide whispers through the mangrove roots.

Kali-Tantrik arrived during the Great Flood — the one that submerged four villages and left three hundred dead. While rescue boats searched for survivors, the tantric walked through chest-deep water as if the flood made a path for him. He pulled corpses from the mud and pressed his skull-staff against their foreheads. They stood. They walked. They returned to their grieving families, who were so desperate for comfort that they did not ask how the dead could walk.

By the time Sundarvani understood what was happening, half the Sundarbans' dead had been raised — not as zombies, but as something worse: people who looked and spoke normally but whose eyes held the flat emptiness of swamp water. They obeyed Kali-Tantrik not because he commanded them, but because he held the thread that connected them to the living world. Cut the thread, and they would dissolve back into the mud.

The Battle of the Black Water was fought at the confluence of three rivers, on a moonless night. Sundarvani's Jal-Jaal caught three of the tantric's undead warriors, and as her net touched their skin, they wept — the first emotion any of them had shown since their return. The net, woven from mangrove bark and blessed by Bonbibí herself, was the one thing that could remind the dead what they had lost.

But Kali-Tantrik escaped into the deepest swamp, where the water is black and the kingfishers refuse to dive. He took the rest of his undead army with him, and the white-throated kingfishers have been heard keening — a sound they make only when death walks the water.

Sundarvani patrols the river-borders with her fishing cat beside her. Its eyes see in darkness that would blind a human. And sometimes, in the deepest part of the night, she sees a figure standing in the mangroves — a woman carrying a bowl of rice, watching her with eyes that might be alive and might not be.

Her mother? Or one of the tantric's creations?

The swamp does not answer. The swamp never answers. It only swallows.

Vajra Bhumi — The Poet And The Conqueror

Bihar is where empires are born and where they come to die. The Mauryas rose here. The Guptas shone here. Nalanda's light illuminated the world from here. And all of it crumbled into the Gangetic mud, leaving a land rich in history and poor in everything else.

Vajramukha carries this contradiction in his fists. When he punches, the gaur-rage channels 2,500 years of martial glory — the same soil that trained Chandragupta, that armed Ashoka, that conquered from Afghanistan to Bengal. When he writes poetry afterward, his verses carry 2,500 years of wisdom — the same soil where Buddha sat beneath a tree and said "enough."

He cannot reconcile these two selves. His wife Prabhavati bears the scar of this failure — a mark across her shoulder from the night his battle-rage did not switch off fast enough. He wears wrist bands now, tied over his gauntlets, each one inscribed with a line of poetry. When the rage begins to take him, the bands tighten and the words press into his skin, reminding him: you are more than the charge.

Ashoka-Chaya found the war diary under Kumhrar — the ruins of ancient Pataliputra. The diary was not written in ink but in the impressions of a stylus pressed hard enough to score stone. The words were Ashoka's battle plans for campaigns that history says he never fought — the invasions he would have launched had Kalinga not broken him. China. Southeast Asia. Arabia. The plans were brilliant, merciless, and complete.

The professor read them and something shifted in Bihar's soil. The ground at Kumhrar cracked. An Ashokan war-pillar that had lain buried for millennia rose six inches. And the professor felt the forgotten rage of an emperor who had been forced to become gentle when every fiber of his being screamed for conquest.

The first attack was on Nalanda's modern campus. Ashoka-Chaya marched with his stone pillar-weapon and fifty followers who had read the diary's pages. They moved like a Mauryan legion — disciplined, silent, devastating. Vajramukha met them at the library door and fought for six hours, his gauntlets cracking against the stone pillar until sparks flew like festival fireworks.

Neither won. But the library was saved — barely — and the Indian Rollers that nest in Nalanda's ruins were seen carrying fragments of palm-leaf manuscripts to safety, as if they

remembered what happened the last time a library burned in Bihar.

The Nalanda-Acharya watches both men from her hidden archive and says nothing. Her manuscript, she claims, contains the answer — but the answer requires a reader who is both warrior and poet, both furious and gentle, both gaur and Buddha.

Vajramukha might be that reader. If he can stop punching long enough to read.

Vana Agni — The War Beneath The Roots

Jharkhand means "Land of Forests." Not "Land of Mines." Not "Land of Resources." Land of Forests. Vanajara was born in a village where the forest canopy was so thick that children grew up not knowing the sky was blue — they thought it was green, the color of leaves.

He was twelve when the machines came. Not the small machines that scratch the surface — the big ones, with teeth of steel and stomachs that swallowed mountains. They came with papers that said the land belonged to someone who had never stood on it, and they told the villagers to move.

Vanajara's father did not move. He stood in front of the first machine, arms crossed, bow on his back. The machine did not stop. The operator later said he did not see a person — he saw a tree, and trees are meant to be removed.

Vanajara hunted that operator. Then the supervisor. Then the district head. By the time he was sixteen, the mining companies had put a bounty on a boy they called "The Forest Ghost." By twenty, he had united three tribal clans into a guerrilla force that made the Western Ghats operations look tame.

Khanij-Raja came to end him — and discovered something unexpected. The boy fought like the forest itself: not with strategy but with ecosystem logic. Attack one point, and the entire forest responds. Cut a root, and the canopy shifts. Chase him into a clearing, and find yourself surrounded by elephants that materialized from the trees like grey ghosts.

The Battle of the Deep Mine was fought underground — in a mine so deep that the temperature exceeded 50 degrees and the darkness was absolute. Vanajara navigated by the sound of his own footsteps echoing off the mine walls, the way a koel navigates by song. Khanij-Raja navigated by the singing of minerals, his drill-arm spinning, carving through stone as easily as Vanajara's arrows carved through air.

They fought in the deepest chamber, where iron ore glowed red in its natural veins and the earth's heartbeat was audible — a low, rhythmic thud that shook dust from the ceiling. Vanajara's arrow struck the drill-arm and it shattered — not because the arrow was strong, but because the iron in the arrowhead recognized the iron in the drill and chose to rejoin its natural form.

Khanij-Raja fled to the surface, weeping for his lost arm and the minerals he could no longer hear singing. But he is rebuilding — this time with a titanium arm, using metal mined from a different, darker place.

Birsa Munda's voice echoes through the Sal forests: "The boy fights well, but fighting is not enough. He must learn to heal what has been broken." The Asian koel sings before dawn, and Vanajara listens, planning his next strike from the canopy.

He is twenty-two. The oldest hero in the Hulmane-The-Saga started at nineteen. Vanajara has time.

The forest has time. The forest always has time.